as if I had had no part to play. One day though, my father sternly called me back, 'Manya, young lad, where do you think you are going? Come back here!.' And so, I stood shoulder to shoulder with my siblings. The age of innocence was over.

One day, my father came back with exciting news. He had been selected for a foreign assignment, as the assistant air attaché to our embassy in Paris, France. In the same breath, he also told us to keep this news to ourselves until it was officially declared, as there could be many a slip between the cup and the lip. This is something I too followed throughout my career—not breathing a word of my likely postings or speculating about them until the orders were issued in black and white. However, there were no slip-ups, and sometime in late October 1965, we embarked on the liner *Guglielmo Marconi*, named after the famous Italian inventor of wireless telegraphy, outbound from Bombay to Genoa, Italy. These small titbits added greatly to my general knowledge, something that would come in very handy in later years. On board the ship, we would explore its many passageways, going from one deck to another, often getting lost in the bargain. For all our meals, we had to go to the central dining area and were served by coat-tailed waiters. There was much excitement when for a few days, the shooting of a Bollywood film took place on board. I don't remember the name, but Shammi Kapoor and Dev Anand were part of the cast. We were on board for about a week or so, sailing via the Red Sea, through the Suez Canal into the Mediterranean Sea, with port calls at Aden and Napoli, before disembarking at Genoa. Then we took an overnight train to Paris, where we arrived by mid-November.

We were initially put up in a hotel before moving into our allotted flat at 4 Rue Faraday (another scientist), in the 17th Arrondissement (Sector) of Paris, just off the Boulevard

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